

GREBES

Birds of ponds and lakes, grebes characteristically swim low in the water and dive propelled by their feet. They feed on small aquatic animals.

Like many other diving birds, grebes have legs that are set far back on the body, making them clumsy on land but agile in water. The toes of their feet are lobed, providing good power strokes during diving, but minimizing drag in the water between strokes. The feet may be used for steering, too; in other diving birds, the tail is used for steering.

A grebe's tail is nothing more than a tuft of feathers. This serves more as a social signal than as a rudder, and is often cocked to expose white feathers beneath. The plumage is dense and well waterproofed by an oil gland. Uniquely in birds,

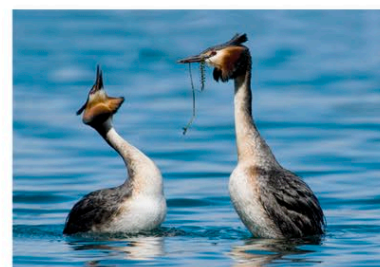
the gland produces a secretion that is 50 per cent paraffin. Grebes have small wings and many species are often reluctant to fly, although northern species are migratory, travelling from inland habitats to the coast to overwinter.

Traditionally, grebes, the order Podicipediformes, are classified as close relatives of divers, penguins, and albatrosses. However, new research suggests that they may be related to flamingos.

RITUAL AND REPRODUCTION

In the breeding season, some grebes perform elaborate courtship rituals. They nest on floating mats of vegetation in freshwater habitats. The young are fully mobile upon hatching and can swim, but seek refuge on a parent's back for the first few weeks.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PODICIPEDIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	23



The courtship ritual of the great crested grebe culminates with both birds rising up from the water clutching a clump of weed.

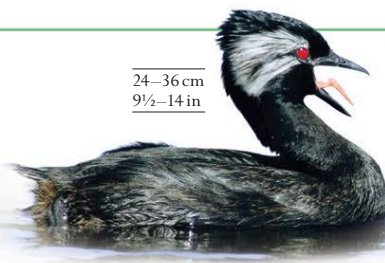
23–29 cm
9–11½ in



LITTLE GREBE
Tachybaptus ruficollis
F: Podicipedidae

Found across the Old World, this bird is the most widespread of the small, dumpy grebes known as dabchicks. It has a reddish neck when breeding.

24–36 cm
9½–14 in



WHITE-TUFTED GREBE
Rollandia rolland
F: Podicipedidae

A native of southern S. America, this is a bird of open lakes with abundant water weeds. A related short-winged Andean species is flightless.

30–38 cm
12–15 in



PIED-BILLED GREBE
Podilymbus podiceps
F: Podicipedidae

This American bird is more stocky and has a stubbier bill than other grebes. Northern birds overwinter in the Caribbean, but tropical populations are sedentary.

40–50 cm
16–20 in



RED-NECKED GREBE
Podiceps grisegena
F: Podicipedidae

This species breeds in Eurasia and N. America and overwinters further south in coastal waters. Like other grebes, it migrates at night.

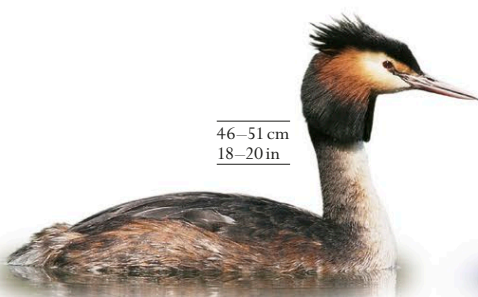
28–34 cm
11–13½ in



BLACK-NECKED GREBE
Podiceps nigricollis
F: Podicipedidae

Like other *Podiceps* grebes, this sharp-billed diver has a colourful head plumage when breeding. It is found across the northern hemisphere.

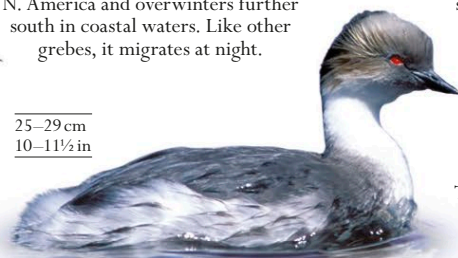
46–51 cm
18–20 in



GREAT CRESTED GREBE
Podiceps cristatus
F: Podicipedidae

This Old World grebe is known for its courtship display. Like other grebes, both sexes are colourful.

25–29 cm
10–11½ in

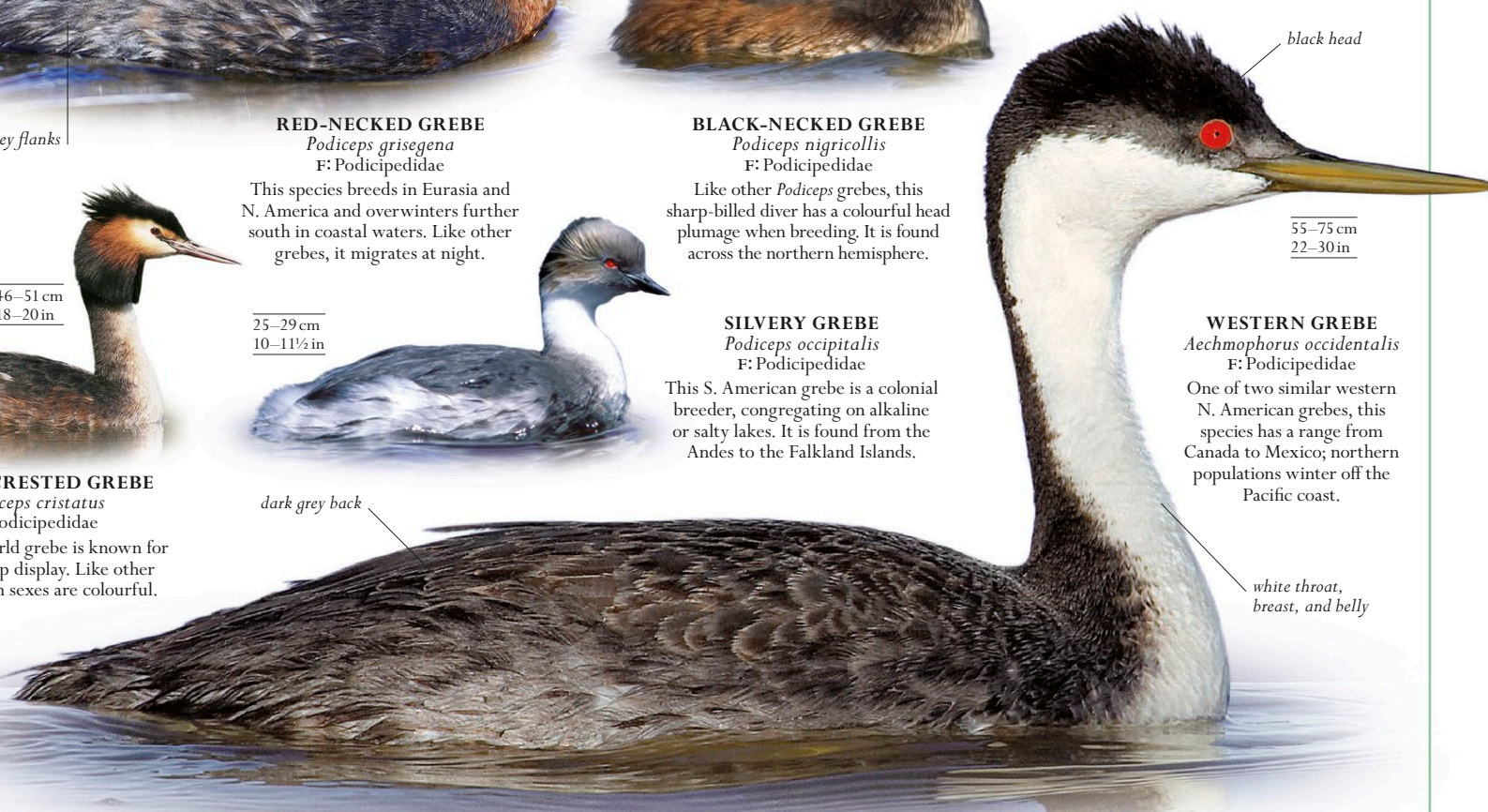


SILVER GREBE
Podiceps occipitalis
F: Podicipedidae

This S. American grebe is a colonial breeder, congregating on alkaline or salty lakes. It is found from the Andes to the Falkland Islands.

black head

55–75 cm
22–30 in



WESTERN GREBE
Aechmophorus occidentalis
F: Podicipedidae

One of two similar western N. American grebes, this species has a range from Canada to Mexico; northern populations winter off the Pacific coast.

white throat,
breast, and belly

dark grey back